



THE ANVIL



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NEWSLETTER OF THE MELBOURNE ANARCHIST COMMUNIST GROUP

Vol 9, No 5

Sept 2020 - Oct 2020

Free

NO MORE PRESIDENTS



Credit: Washington Monthly

As we go to press, the US Presidential election is fast approaching. Joe Biden, the Democratic candidate, is further ahead in the polls than Hillary Clinton was four years ago and his lead is pretty stable. Trump can only win by either a massive last-minute shift in opinion or by undemocratic means. These could include the Electoral College, semi-legal methods of voter suppression or an outright illegal refusal to count postal votes. So many conventions of US politics have been broken in recent years that we hesitate to rule out any scenario as impossible. There is even discussion about whether Trump would be prepared to recognise an election in which he was defeated.

With our limited resources, picking a winner would be a mug's game, so we will

reflect on the meaning of the election and the point at which US society finds itself. The Melbourne Anarchist Communist Group believes it is impossible to hold executive office in the capitalist state on a principled basis. Being President of the USA involves being Commander-in-Chief of the world's most powerful imperialist military, maintaining a deadly repressive domestic and foreign security apparatus and administering myriad unjust laws. You could institute the world's most thorough reform program, but you'd still be committing crimes 24 hours a day. It is impossible to ever support any candidate for US President, even one whom it might be permissible to support for election to a legislative body.

Donald Trump was elected in 2016 because five decades of neoliberalism had produced the worst inequality in the US in over a century. Far from reversing inequality, Trump has aggravated it and the COVID-19 pandemic has accelerated even further the transfer of wealth to the very richest. Simultaneously, Trump is abolishing the checks and balances that protect the U.S.A. from open dictatorship. Meanwhile, Joe Biden is promising to be "a normal President" - i.e. to continue the same policies that created the conditions for Trump to be elected.

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Neither candidate offers anything to the working class.

The current situation is unsustainable. The balance of power between capitalists and workers is so uneven that US inequality will increase until the working class revolts and builds powerful new organisations. Until then, the sectors of the population who have a stake in the system will progressively reduce. The political centre will continue to dissolve. Society will polarise into Left and Right and, at some point, a showdown will occur.

What should Anarchists do?

The task of Anarchists in the United States is to build the struggle of the multi-racial, multicultural and gender diverse working class against poverty and against racism, sexism and all other oppressions. If Biden wins, the growing Fascist movement in the US will react with great violence, though perhaps not immediately. If Trump wins, his re-election will be greeted with rage by a growing grassroots movement that already rejects US institutions as

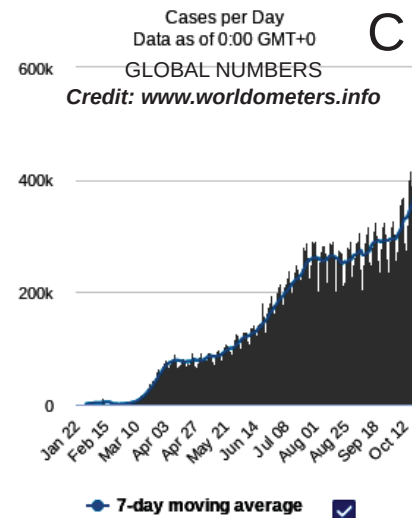
illegitimate. The need for revolutionary struggle will be more obvious.

In either case, it is by building working class struggle that the threat of Fascism will be best addressed. Struggle against a re-elected Trump would be necessary as he accelerates the class polarisation of society and moves further towards dictatorship. Struggle against a President Biden would explode the poisonous identification of the Left with the Democratic Party that Republicans make and from which Fascists benefit.

The United States is headed for a crisis which, one way or another, will destroy it as the sole super-power. A vote for neither candidate would change that for the better. Only the working class can save the US from Fascism and war. And this can only be done by destroying the United States in a workers' revolution.

NO TRUMP
NO WALL
NO USA AT ALL

Daily New Cases



COVID & CAPITALISM

The virus causing COVID-19 seems, at last, to be under control in Australia. In the northern hemisphere, though, it is a different matter altogether. As the northern autumn deepens, diagnosed cases are rising strongly and are at record levels across much of Europe and elsewhere. Hospitals are filling rapidly and many governments that had opened up their national economies are locking them down again. Deaths have risen sharply in the last month and will go higher.

A lot has been learnt since January about SARS-CoV-2, the virus that causes COVID-19. The death rate is somewhat lower than at first feared, but still an order of magnitude greater than influenza. Re-infection, though possible, has been rare. More alarming, though, is that recovery from the virus doesn't mean recovery from the disease. A substantial minority who get COVID-19 suffer sometimes serious effects which last months after the infection is cleared. Some effects may be permanent. In addition, it appears that immunity acquired from catching the virus and recovering may be short-lived.

The result is the COVID-19 pandemic is an ongoing disaster to which the capitalists in most countries have no effective response. Elimination or suppression has been achieved in only a few countries. As yet, there is no proven vaccine and no guarantee that a sufficiently effective one will be found in the medium term, let alone soon. Further, even the criminal policies advocated by the hard Right wouldn't work. Capitulation to the virus wouldn't save the capitalist economy at the price of culling the old and sick. Instead, repeated waves of the virus would impose increasing ill health and disability on the workforce. Meanwhile, people's rational attempts to prevent themselves being infected would savage consumer spending and send national economies into the same tailspin that the Right's policies are intended to prevent.

What is required to defeat the virus?

SARS-CoV-2 is spread mostly through close contact, so until the virus is sufficiently suppressed, we need to minimise contact between people who don't live in the same household. At that point, it can be tackled through testing

potentially infected people, quarantining them and tracing their contacts. Until then, as much economic and social activity as possible must be conducted remotely or ceased.

Under capitalism, this strategy has catastrophic economic consequences. Business turnover drops massively and huge losses accumulate. The normal relationship between the event basis of the productive economy of goods and services and the time basis of the parasitic economy of rent and interest is broken. Government responses to ameliorate the crisis increase public debt to unprecedented levels that threaten the solvency of states. So, instead of paying everyone to stay home and not spread the virus, most governments have taken half-measures or, having imposed a lockdown, opened up the economy before the virus is beaten.

A libertarian communist society would have no such conflicted motives. Without the drive for profits, production of non-essential goods and services could cease, while all necessary resources could be re-allocated to supporting the health care system. Physical distancing restrictions would be developed at the grassroots on the basis of expert advice and have greater community ownership, negating the need for police enforcement. And, importantly, all appropriate social support would be given to soften the hardships of isolation.

The current task

To beat this pandemic, the working class needs a fighting program which attacks the power of the capitalists who stand in the road of an effective public health response. Accordingly, the Melbourne

Anarchist Communist Group supports the following program in advanced countries where the virus is not yet suppressed:

- No safety, no work. Appropriate physical distancing in all workplaces; adequate staffing, personal protective equipment and training; closure of non-essential industries where physical distancing is impossible.
- A living income for all. Full pay for all furloughed workers; pandemic leave for all, for as long as necessary, as often as necessary; unemployment benefits at the minimum wage where they don't already exceed it.
- Housing security. Cancellation of rent and home mortgage interest for the duration of the pandemic; no evictions; house the homeless.
- Free and adequate health care for all.

Workers need to fight for this program in the workplace. Rank and file health & safety committees need to form and link up. They must refuse unsafe conditions and, where possible, impose adequate health and safety measures directly. And they need to confront the union officials with an ultimatum: support the struggle or be swept aside.

The struggle we advocate will reveal to millions how capitalism and human needs are opposed. It would germinate the power that could do something about it. It can be the beginning of a revolutionary movement.

**FIGHT THE VIRUS!
NO SAFETY, NO WORK!**

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What is Anarchism?

Anarchism is a social philosophy based upon the principles of liberty, equality and solidarity. It is the political dimension of a free society.

What is Communism?

Communism is the principle of "from each according to their ability, to each according to their need". It is the economic dimension of a free society.

What is the Melbourne Anarchist Communist Group?

The MACG is an organisation of class struggle revolutionary anarchists who share political positions, articulated in theory, strategy and tactics. We aim to encourage struggle by the working class for its own interests and, within that struggle, we aim to advance Anarchist ideas as its necessary philosophical basis.